Other Battlezones



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SHAHI JAMA MASJID | *Sambhal*

THE ROW

The 16th-century mosque in UP is embroiled in a legal dispute with claims that it was built on Babur's orders after razing Harihar Mandir, dedicated to Lord Kalki. The dispute boiled over into violence in November 2024 during a court-ordered survey of the mosque.

THE PETITIONERS

The legal challenge is led by Supreme Court lawyer V.S. Jain and seer Mahant Rishiraj Giri, backed by Hindutva groups.

CURRENT STATUS

The SC has stayed further trial court proceedings till the Allahabad High Court decides the mosque committee's challenge to the survey order. It has also ordered status quo over a disputed well near the mosque. The next HC hearing is on April 8.

GYANVAPI MOSQUE | *Varanasi*

THE ROW

A similar story is playing out in Varanasi, where a 2023 ASI survey has confirmed a pre-existing temple at the Gyanvapi Masjid's site. Hindu groups claim that the 17th-century mosque was built on the plinth of the Vishweshwara temple razed by Aurangzeb. The dispute only intensified after a 2022 survey found a shivling-like structure in the mosque's *wuzukhana* (ablution tank).

THE PETITIONERS

The conflict originally traces back to a 1991 lawsuit but gained momentum in August 2021 when five Hindu women filed a petition, seeking permission to worship the goddess Shringar Gauri inside the mosque compound all year round. It is spearheaded by lawyer Hari Shankar Jain, who is also involved in Shahi Idgah and Taj Mahal cases.

CURRENT STATUS

In early 2024, a Varanasi court allowed Hindus to pray in the mosque's basement, a ruling upheld by the Allahabad High Court. Later, the Supreme Court, too, refused to pause the *puja*. Multiple litigations are still pending in courts.



simmer over the Bhagyalaxmi temple, located below the southeastern minaret of the iconic Charminar. Just five months earlier, a fresh battle erupted over the Shahi Jama Masjid, a 16th-century structure and reputedly the oldest surviving Mughal mosque in the country, in Sambhal, UP.

It's not just religious structures, but names of roads, towns, and even festivals commemorating Muslim figures from history or legend are falling victim to the Hindutva pursuit to reclaim history. Thus the renaming of Aurangabad as Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar and the rechristening of Osmanabad district as Dharashiv, and Ahmednagar as Ahilyanagar after the 18th-century warrior queen Ahilyabai Holkar. Allahabad and Mughalsarai have been rechristened Prayagraj and Pandit Deen Dayal Upadhyay Nagar for some time now.

In the Hindutva view of things, these are nothing but efforts to set right the distorted view of history promoted by imperialist and Left historians. Sangh parivar ideologues cite the '*panch pran*' (five resolutions) of the Amrit Kaal propounded by PM Modi as the core of their ideology. These include the goal of a developed India by 2047, elimination of colonial